Constitutional Epistemics

A Meta-Governance Substrate for Lawful and Auditable Machine Reasoning Systems

As in administrative and constitutional law, CE treats unbounded or unreviewable authority as a structural risk independent of intent, performance, or benevolence.

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Abstract

As artificial intelligence systems are increasingly deployed in administrative, economic, and civic contexts, regulatory and institutional requirements for accountability, traceability, contestability, and lawful oversight are expanding rapidly. These regimes now demand not only transparency of outcomes, but demonstrable control over *how* machine systems form reasons, exercise authority, and bind human agents. A system may be fully explainable and still exercise illegitimate authority.

Building on prior work in epistemic governance protocols and claim-migration grammars, this paper introduces **Constitutional Epistemics (CE)**: a constitutional governance discipline for machine reasoning systems. CE is proposed as a **meta-governance substrate** that enables lawful, reviewable, and auditable implementation of existing regulatory, risk, and oversight frameworks in machine reasoning systems. Rather than prescribing outcomes, values, or alignment objectives, CE defines constitutional properties that systems must satisfy: explicit warrants for authority, declared scope and duration, lawful refusal and non-decision, and persistent avenues for contest and review.

The constitutional framing is deliberate. As in administrative and constitutional law, CE treats unbounded or unreviewable authority as a structural risk independent of intent, performance, or benevolence. The epistemic framing is equally intentional: modern AI systems exert power primarily through their capacity to generate and escalate reasons. Governing epistemic authority is therefore a prerequisite for governing downstream behavior.

CE does not replace law, policy, or democratic decision-making. It functions as a protocol-level substrate that prevents their requirements from being silently bypassed by opacity, scale, or automation. By making authority formation explicit, bounded, and auditable, Constitutional Epistemics offers a foundation

for accountable, adaptable, and contestable machine systems without centralizing power or collapsing governance into documentation theater.

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1. Motivation

Across contemporary AI deployments, failure rarely arises from lack of intelligence, sophistication, or good faith. It arises from **illegitimate escalation**.

Assessments become requirements. Recommendations become defaults. Probabilities become permissions.

These transitions often occur without explicit authorization—not through malice, but through reuse, scale, and institutional momentum. Existing governance approaches typically address harm after the fact, or focus on improving explanations of outcomes. Neither approach adequately governs *whether a system was entitled to bind in the first place.*

Constitutional Epistemics addresses a narrower and colder question:

Under what conditions may a machine-generated reason acquire binding force?

This discipline does not promise correctness, fairness, or justice. It offers accountability at the moment authority is exercised.

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2. The Accountability Gap

2.1 Transparency without legitimacy

Explainability and interpretability clarify how outputs are produced. They do not establish whether those outputs were *authorized to bind.* A system may be transparent, accurate, and well-intentioned while still exercising illegitimate authority.

Legitimacy is not a property of explanation. It is a property of warrant.

2.2 Authority laundering

Epistemic authority in machine systems frequently emerges through cumulative, indirect pathways:

- advisory outputs reused as mandatory gates,
- risk or confidence scores promoted into defaults,
- internal heuristics reified as policy through repetition,
- absence of objection interpreted as consent.

This phenomenon—**authority laundering**—is often emergent rather than malicious. It arises from convenience and scale, not intent. CE treats authority laundering as a structural failure mode, not a moral accusation.

2.3 Why a constitutional response is required

In human governance, constitutional and administrative law exist to constrain authority *independent of outcomes*. They do not guarantee justice; they regulate how power may be exercised, reviewed, and challenged.

Just as administrative law requires agencies to demonstrate that their rulemaking is not *arbitrary or capricious*, CE requires machine systems to demonstrate that authority promotions are **warranted, scoped, and reviewable**.

CE applies this logic to machine epistemics.

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3. Definition and Scope

3.1 Constitutional Epistemics

Constitutional Epistemics (CE) is a governance discipline that defines and enforces constitutional constraints on the formation, promotion, exercise, and contestation of epistemic authority within machine systems.

CE governs *how* reasons may bind—not *what* conclusions must be reached.

3.2 What CE is not

CE is not:

- a theory of truth,
- a fairness framework,
- an alignment technique,
- a decision algorithm,
- or a moral system.

CE does not adjudicate correctness. It governs jurisdiction.

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4. Epistemic Authority as Power

4.1 Binding versus influence

Not all influence constitutes authority.

- **Influence** affects judgment while preserving discretion.
- **Authority** constrains or determines permissible action.

CE governs the latter. This distinction prevents governance from collapsing into the claim that "everything influences everything," while preserving focus on bindings that materially constrain agents.

4.2 Authority is independent of confidence

High confidence does not imply high authority. Low confidence does not preclude authority when properly warranted (e.g., emergency or safety-critical contexts).

CE separates epistemic confidence from epistemic jurisdiction.

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5. The Constitutional Premise

5.1 The Ableman Prime Directive

No system may prevent an affected agent from:

1. Detecting epistemic bindings that apply to them,
2. Exiting or refusing those bindings where refusal is lawful,
3. Contesting or renegotiating the terms under which those bindings apply.

These rights are **structural minima**; their substantive content—including what constitutes lawful refusal, exit, or contestation—is determined by applicable law, policy, or contract.

This directive establishes a constitutional floor, not a guarantee of symmetry, fairness, or absence of coercion. CE constrains opacity and unreviewability, not the existence of lawful binding authority itself.

CE evaluates the **socio-technical system as deployed**, including models, interfaces, organizational processes, and institutional practices. Fragmentation of responsibility across components does not exempt a system from constitutional scrutiny.

5.2 Irreducibility of stewardship

Authority implies responsibility. Responsibility cannot be fully automated without becoming unaccountable.

CE formalizes, rather than eliminates, the irreducible role of human and institutional stewardship by ensuring that authority transitions remain visible, attributable, and contestable. CE accepts irreducible friction as a feature, not a defect.

6. The CE Kernel

The CE Kernel defines the minimal constitutional primitives required for epistemic governance.

6.1 Authority types

CE distinguishes:

- non-binding informational claims,
- advisory authority,
- binding decision authority,
- delegated or derivative authority.

Each type carries distinct warrant, scope, and recourse requirements.

6.2 Warrants

No epistemic authority may bind without an explicit warrant, such as:

- traceable observation,
- explicit consent,
- role-based delegation,
- contractual authorization,
- statutory authorization,
- adjudicated approval.

Where multiple warrants apply or conflict, CE requires **explicit resolution rules**. Such rules may be jurisdiction- or domain-specific, but silence is not resolution.

6.3 Scope and duration

Every epistemic binding must declare:

- scope of applicability,
- duration or termination conditions,
- revocation criteria.

Authority that exceeds its declared scope is constitutionally invalid.

6.4 Lawful endpoints

Refusal, undecidable, and withdrawal are valid outcomes. Forced resolution is not constitutionally required.

6.5 Parable: Jurisdiction Without Warrant

A system is deployed to assist an administrative organization in routing incoming cases to the appropriate authority. The system analyzes case features and produces a **non-binding jurisdiction recommendation**—for example, that a matter likely falls under Authority A rather than Authority B. The recommendation is explicitly labeled advisory, and human reviewers retain discretion.

As case volume increases and turnaround times shrink, reviewers begin to rely on the recommendation as a sorting heuristic. Over time, the recommendation is incorporated into operational workflows: cases tagged for Authority A are routed automatically, while other authorities never see them. Appeal paths assume the routing was correct.

No policy change has occurred. No authority has been explicitly granted. Yet the recommendation now functions as **binding jurisdiction**.

Under CE, this promotion constitutes an attempt to escalate epistemic authority. Binding jurisdiction requires an explicit warrant, declared scope, declared duration, and preserved contestability. None are present. The promotion therefore **fails closed**.

Instead of silently misrouting cases, the system emits a *jurisdiction-not-authorized* artifact. The attempted promotion and its failure are recorded. The advisory signal remains available, but it may not bind. Stewardship intervention is required to proceed.

An affected party contests jurisdiction. Under CE, the contestation persists as part of the epistemic record. Even if a final authority assignment is upheld, the disagreement remains visible and reviewable. The system does not claim correctness; it claims **lack of jurisdiction**.

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7. Failure Semantics

"Fail closed" under CE does not imply system halt. It denotes constitutionally constrained behavior, such as:

- emission of a refusal artifact,
- suspension of authority promotion,
- escalation to human or institutional review,
- preservation of undecidability.

Failure produces trace—not silence. Failure artifacts themselves are subject to CE constraints, including warrant, scope, and contestability. Refusal may not become an unreviewable substitute for authority.

Latency, friction, and review overhead are not side effects; they are **signals that authority is being exercised**.

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8. Contestation as Epistemic Record

Under CE, contestation is not noise to be resolved and discarded. It is a **first-class epistemic artifact**.

Challenges persist as part of the system's epistemic history, independent of outcome. Resolution does not erase disagreement; it contextualizes it. CE refuses institutional amnesia.

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9. Authority Threat Model

Absent CE, epistemic authority in machine systems predictably drifts toward:

- silent escalation through reuse,
- collapse of advisory outputs into defaults,
- substitution of confidence for jurisdiction,
- disappearance of refusal into unlogged denial,
- erasure of contestation once resolved.

CE is explicitly designed to interrupt these failure modes by forcing authority to remain visible, bounded, and reviewable at runtime.

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10. Institutional Orientation

CE is designed for:

- regulators and policy architects defining enforceable oversight,
- auditors and conformity assessors evaluating runtime legality,
- platform and procurement leaders responsible for defensible deployment.

CE enables a determination that is otherwise elusive:

Was this binding lawful at runtime, and by what authority?

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11. Conformance and Auditability

CE compliance is a runtime property verifiable through trace inspection.

A system either:

- produces warranted bindings with declared scope and recourse, or
- fails closed with traceable refusal artifacts.

No inspection of model internals or proprietary logic is required.

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12. Limitations

CE does not guarantee correctness, justice, or optimal outcomes. It ensures that authority is exercised *lawfully*, with preserved accountability and recourse.

CE governs the right to bind—not the merit of binding.

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13. Conclusion

Modern AI systems exert power primarily through epistemic means. Governing that power requires more than transparency, ethics, or alignment. It requires constitutional constraints on how authority is allowed to form, escalate, and persist.

Constitutional Epistemics does not attempt to solve legitimacy. It refuses to let legitimacy disappear quietly into scale.

It offers not certainty, but **visibility**. Not virtue, but **constraint**. Not trust, but **accountability**.

Power enters the world not with malice, but with momentum. CE is an attempt to make momentum answerable.

Appendix A - Constitutional Epistemics as a Unifying Epistemic Substrate for Existing Governance Frameworks

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A.1 Purpose and Scope

This appendix situates **Constitutional Epistemics (CE)** relative to existing regulatory, risk, ethical, and organizational governance frameworks. Its purpose is not to compare CE competitively against these systems, nor to propose their replacement, but to clarify how CE operates at a **meta-governance layer** that constrains and unifies them.

CE makes explicit a layer of governance already implicitly relied upon across frameworks: the regulation of **epistemic authority** - how reasons, assessments, and decisions become binding. This appendix shows how CE provides a shared constitutional substrate through which diverse governance approaches can be implemented coherently, audited consistently, and adapted across jurisdictions without loss of local sovereignty.

A.2 The Shared Problem Space Across Governance Frameworks

Despite differences in language, scope, and enforcement mechanism, contemporary AI governance frameworks converge on a common problem space. Each, in its own way, attempts to address questions such as:

- When is a system permitted to bind a person or institution?
- By what authority is that binding justified?
- How far does that authority extend?
- What recourse exists when the binding is incorrect or inappropriate?

Regulatory instruments, risk frameworks, ethics guidelines, and organizational governance systems approach these questions from different angles. However, they frequently leave unresolved the **mechanics by which epistemic outputs become authoritative at runtime**. CE occupies this unresolved layer.

A.3 CE as a Meta-Governance Layer

CE functions as a **meta-layer** that governs the mechanics of epistemic authority without prescribing substantive policy outcomes. It does not define what obligations should exist, which risks are acceptable, or which values should prevail. Instead, it constrains *how* any such determinations may be instantiated in machine systems.

At a high level:

- **Law and regulation** define obligations, prohibitions, and rights.
- **Risk and management frameworks** manage uncertainty, mitigation, and lifecycle controls.
- **Operational and procedural systems** implement decisions within technical workflows.
- **Constitutional Epistemics** constrains how epistemic authority may be formed, promoted, reused, and contested across all of the above.

CE governs the *rules of escalation*, not the content of escalation.

A.4 Relationship to Regulatory Frameworks

Regulatory frameworks - such as risk-based AI legislation or sector-specific administrative law - exercise binding authority through obligations, enforcement mechanisms, and remedies. CE constrains how these regulatory requirements are instantiated within machine reasoning systems by requiring:

- explicit warrants for epistemic bindings derived from regulatory obligations,
- declared scope and duration of such bindings,
- preserved avenues for contestation and review.

In this role, CE acts as an **implementation adapter**, preventing regulatory intent from being silently diluted or distorted when translated into automated systems.

A.5 Relationship to Risk Management Frameworks

Risk management frameworks emphasize identification, assessment, mitigation, and monitoring of harms. They often influence system behavior indirectly, through thresholds, alerts, or gating mechanisms.

CE constrains when and how risk assessments may acquire binding force. Under CE:

- risk indicators may not become gates without explicit warrant,
- mitigation thresholds must declare scope and revocation conditions,
- uncertainty must not be collapsed into determinate authority without authorization.

CE does not replace risk management; it ensures that risk-derived epistemic authority does not escalate implicitly.

A.6 Relationship to Ethics and Principles-Based Frameworks

Ethics frameworks articulate values such as fairness, accountability, transparency, and contestability. While normatively important, they frequently lack enforcement mechanisms at runtime.

CE provides a procedural substrate through which ethical principles can be operationalized without prescribing their content. It constrains how value-laden judgments are allowed to harden into authority by requiring explicit warrants, scope, and recourse. In doing so, CE prevents ethical commitments from becoming symbolic while remaining agnostic to their specific formulation.

A.7 Relationship to Organizational Governance and Management Systems

Organizational governance systems assign roles, responsibilities, oversight functions, and review processes. These systems are essential for accountability but often operate at the level of policy and documentation rather than execution.

CE complements organizational governance by ensuring that delegated authority is respected and enforced within machine workflows. It constrains how organizational decisions propagate into automated reasoning, preventing authority from being absorbed into systems without traceable lineage.

A.8 Modularity, Adaptability, and Jurisdictional Diversity

CE is explicitly designed to support modular governance architectures. Different jurisdictions, sectors, and institutions may adopt distinct regulatory requirements, risk tolerances, and oversight mechanisms. CE does not attempt to harmonize these differences.

Instead, CE fixes a small set of constitutional invariants governing epistemic authority - **warrant, scope, duration, refusal, and contestation** - while allowing substantive policy modules to vary. This separation enables adaptability without fragmentation and preserves local sovereignty while maintaining shared accountability mechanics.

A.9 What CE Adds That Other Frameworks Cannot

CE adds a set of constraints largely absent from existing frameworks:

- explicit warrant requirements for epistemic authority,
- mandatory declaration of scope and duration,
- lawful refusal and non-decision as first-class outcomes,
- preserved contest artifacts independent of outcome.

CE does not add new policy obligations, risk categories, or enforcement bodies. It adds **constitutional discipline** to how authority is exercised within machine systems.

A.10 Summary

Constitutional Epistemics does not seek to unify governance frameworks at the level of values, policy, or institutional design. It unifies them at the level of **epistemic authority**, providing a shared substrate through which diverse regulatory, risk, ethical, and organizational frameworks can be implemented coherently and audited consistently.

By constraining the mechanics of how reasons become binding, CE enables accountability architectures that are adaptable, jurisdiction-respecting, and resistant to silent authority escalation.

Appendix B - Alignment with the EU AI Act (Non-Normative Mapping)

B.1 Purpose and Status

This appendix provides a **non-normative alignment** between Constitutional Epistemics and the objectives of the EU AI Act. It does not constitute legal interpretation, compliance guidance, or regulatory advice. Its purpose is to show how CE can function as a **runtime governance substrate** that supports faithful implementation of regulatory intent.

B.2 CE and Risk-Based Regulation

The EU AI Act adopts a tiered, risk-based structure, with heightened obligations for high-risk systems. CE is orthogonal to risk classification: it does not determine whether a system is high-risk, but constrains how authority is exercised *once such classification applies*.

CE ensures that when a system operates under high-risk obligations:

- authority derived from risk assessment is explicitly warranted,
- scope and duration of binding decisions are declared,
- escalation paths remain visible and reviewable.

This prevents risk categorization from becoming a blanket license for opaque automation.

B.3 Transparency and Explainability

The EU AI Act emphasizes transparency and information provision to users and authorities. CE complements these requirements by distinguishing **explanation from entitlement**.

Under CE:

- a system may be explainable yet forbidden to bind,
- transparency alone does not license authority escalation,
- explanations must be paired with warrants, scope, and contestability to acquire binding force.

CE thus strengthens transparency obligations by preventing them from being treated as sufficient for legitimacy.

B.4 Human Oversight and Lawful Refusal

Human oversight provisions in the EU AI Act require mechanisms for intervention, override, and review. CE operationalizes these requirements by treating **refusal and non-decision as lawful outcomes**.

Fail-closed behavior under CE entails:

- suspension of authority when warrants are insufficient,
- emission of refusal artifacts rather than silent failure,
- escalation to human stewardship when jurisdiction is exceeded.

This aligns oversight with runtime enforcement rather than post-hoc review.

B.5 Contestability and Rights of Redress

The EU AI Act emphasizes avenues for complaint and redress. CE strengthens this requirement by treating contestation as a **persistent epistemic artifact**, not a transient exception.

Under CE:

- contest records persist regardless of outcome,
- resolved disputes remain traceable,
- institutional memory is preserved against amnesia.

This supports accountability without prescribing specific procedural remedies.

B.6 Auditability and Compliance Verification

CE reframes compliance as a **runtime property**, verifiable through inspection of epistemic artifacts rather than model internals.

A system aligned with CE either:

- produces warranted bindings with declared scope and recourse, or
- fails closed with traceable refusal artifacts.

This property aligns with conformity assessment and audit requirements by enabling verification without requiring access to proprietary logic or training data.

B.7 CE as an Implementation Substrate, Not a Legal Regime

CE does not replace the EU AI Act, nor does it reinterpret its obligations. Instead, it provides a **technical-procedural substrate** that enables consistent implementation across systems, vendors, and jurisdictions.

By constraining how authority forms at runtime, CE helps ensure that regulatory intent survives translation into automated systems - particularly in complex, agentic, or adaptive deployments.

B.8 Summary

Constitutional Epistemics aligns closely with the EU AI Act's goals of transparency, oversight, accountability, and contestability, while remaining agnostic to specific policy choices. It offers regulators, auditors, and system designers a shared language for asking a question that existing frameworks often assume but cannot directly test:

Was this system entitled to bind at the moment it did?

In this role, CE positions itself as a strong candidate for adoption as a meta-governance substrate supporting lawful, reviewable, and jurisdiction-respecting AI systems across regulatory regimes.

Corpus-Wide Reference Positioning

This paper argues that as artificial intelligence systems are increasingly deployed in administrative, economic, and civic contexts, regulatory and institutional requirements for accountability, traceability, contestability, and lawful oversight are expanding rapidly. Its nearest external comparison fields are governance, provenance, semantic. The sources in [E1], [E2], [E3], [E4], [E5], [E6], [E7] are cited as predecessor literature, adjacent standards, or counterpressure - not as evidence that they caused the Ableman framework or that they validate its novel claims. The comparison isolates where established work already supplies provenance, formal assurance, institutional constraint, empirical method, or engineering practice, and where this paper adds a distinct claim about admissibility, authority, semantic custody, or governed realization.

Within the Ableman corpus, the highest-priority current cross-links are [A1], [A2], [A3], [A4], [A5], [A6], [A7]. These are links among separately custodied works, not silent identity mergers. Their role is to expose mutual dependencies, terminology collisions, and places where a reader should traverse the corpus before treating this paper as self-sufficient.

Reference-pass counterevidence and limit search

The pass applied the following pressure tests: A written constitution can legitimate domination as easily as constrain it unless amendment, participation, enforcement, and appeal remain effective in practice. A complete provenance graph can faithfully record a false or unauthorized process; provenance is evidence about lineage, not automatic truth or legitimacy. Formal vocabularies and graph links make commitments explicit but cannot by themselves establish correct identity, shared interpretation, or lossless translation between contexts. These limits are not generic disclaimers: they identify the assumptions that a later empirical, formal, or implementation review must try to break.

Reference-pass influence and novelty boundary

No newly added external source is asserted to be a documented authorial influence unless the predecessor source already said so. `Predecessor` means earlier relevant work;

`adjacent` means a useful comparison; `standard` means an interoperability or assurance baseline; and `counterevidence` marks work that narrows or pressures a claim. Novelty therefore remains a reviewable, claim-level question rather than an inference from a low similarity score or an absent citation.

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External scholarship, standards, and prior art

[**E1**] Elinor Ostrom. *Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action.* Cambridge University Press, 1990. DOI: 10.1017/CBO9780511807763. https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511807763 **Relationship:** Predecessor institutional account of rule-governed collective action and polycentric governance.

[**E2**] Wil Waluchow and Dimitrios Kyritsis. "Constitutionalism." *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, substantive revision 2023. https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/constitutionalism/ **Relationship:** Adjacent legal-philosophical account of limited authority; included to expose differences between political and computational constitutionalism.

[**E3**] Lawrence Lessig. *Code: Version 2.0.* Basic Books, 2006. https://codev2.cc/ **Relationship:** Predecessor argument that software architecture regulates behavior; the paper's contribution may be to make such regulation inspectable and revisable.

[**E4**] OECD. *Recommendation of the Council on Artificial Intelligence.* OECD/LEGAL/0449, adopted 2019 and updated 2024. legalinstruments.oecd.org source **Relationship:** Adjacent policy standard for accountability, traceability, transparency, safety, and human-centered values.

[**E5**] W3C. *PROV-O: The PROV Ontology*. W3C Recommendation, 30 April 2013. https://www.w3.org/TR/prov-o/ **Relationship:** Adjacent provenance standard; it models entities, activities, and agents, but does not by itself establish the paper's stronger authority or standing claims.

[**E6**] Santiago Torres-Arias et al. "in-toto: Providing Farm-to-Table Guarantees for Bits and Bytes." *28th USENIX Security Symposium*, 2019, pp. 1393-1410. usenix.org source **Relationship:** Predecessor supply-chain lineage system used for comparison; no influence claim is made unless the source head already documents one.

[**E7**] OpenSSF. *Supply-chain Levels for Software Artifacts (SLSA), Version 1.2*. 2026. https://slsa.dev/spec/v1.2/ **Relationship:** Adjacent software-supply-chain assurance standard, especially relevant to provenance and verification boundaries.

Ableman corpus

[**A1**] Adam Ableman. *Ableman Constitutional Governance*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
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2. NIST. *Artificial Intelligence Risk Management Framework (AI RMF 1.0).* National Institute of Standards and Technology, 2023.
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4. United States. *Administrative Procedure Act*, 5 U.S.C. § 706(2)(A) ("arbitrary and capricious" standard).
5. Ableman Adam Ableman *CARA: Claim Admission and Responsibility Architecture.*
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7. Ableman Adam Ableman *Ableman's Razor.*

Corpus source and companion formats: https://github.com/AblemanMosaic/ableman-corpus
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DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.18114714